

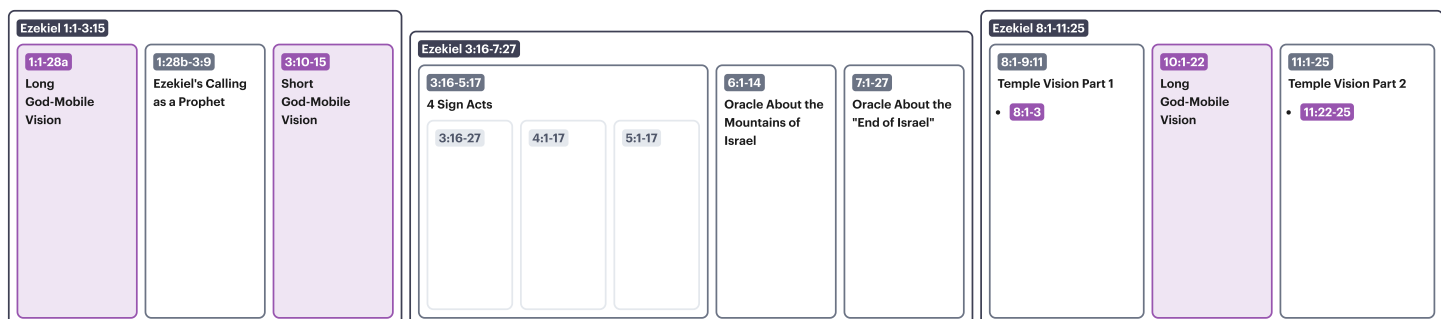
Session 9: Corrupted Temple Vision

Key Takeaways

- God shows Ezekiel a vision of the temple as an anti-Eden.
- The prophets saw a deep connection between idolatry on the one hand and violence and injustice on the other.
- Idolatry is a key theme throughout the Bible as humans choose whether they will accept their role as God's image or give allegiance to images of their own making.

Ezekiel 8-11: Vision of the Temple's Defilement and Jerusalem's Destruction

This large block of narrative and speeches brings the larger movement of Ezekiel 1:1-11:25 to a close. The literary design of this unit is fairly clear, as it opens and closes with a vision of the divine human on the throne of the god-mobile, and in the center is a long description of the god-mobile that matches the scene in [Ezekiel 1](#).



Ezekiel 1:1-11:25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 8:1-11:25

When we examine the literary design of 8:1-11:25 more closely, we find it is a symmetrical arrangement of multiple visionary stories, where Ezekiel is touring the Jerusalem temple with “Spirit-empowered eyes” so that he can see the reality his contemporaries are unable to perceive.

Ezekiel 8:1-9:11 Vision of the Temple's Corruption				Ezekiel 10:1-22 Long God-Mobile Vision			Ezekiel 11:1-25		
8:1-3a	8:3b-18 The Four Abominations 8:3b-6 #1 8:7-13 #2 8:14-15 #3 8:16-18 #4	9:1-11 The City's Virtual Ruin 9:1-7 9:8-10 9:11		10:1-7	10:8-17	10:18-22	11:1-13 Abominable City Leaders 11:1-4 11:5-12 11:13	11:14-21 Judgment and Future Hope 11:14-15 11:16-17 11:18-21	11:22-25 The God-Mobile Leaves the Temple

Ezekiel 8:1-11:25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

8:1 And it came about on the sixth year,
in the sixth [month],
on the fifth of the month,
I was sitting in **my house**
and **the elders of Judah** were sitting before me.
And **the hand of lord Yahweh** came upon me there.

2 And **I saw** and look:
the likeness like **the appearance** of a human:
from **the appearance** of his loins and downward, fire;
and from his loins upward, like **the appearance** of light, like the flash of *hashmal*

3 And he sent out the form of a hand
and he took me by the hair-lock of my head
and **the Spirit/wind** lifted me between the land and the skies
and he brought me to Jerusalem in visions of Elohim,
to the door of **the inner gate** which faces **North**,
where there sat **the idol of jealousy which provokes jealousy**.

4 And look:
there was the glory of the Elohim of Israel,
like the appearance which I saw in the plain.

5 And he said to me,
"Son of a human,
lift up your eyes toward the North."
And **I lifted my eyes to the North**,
and **look**: from the **North of the gate** was the altar,
that **idol of jealousy** was by the entrance

6 And he said to me,
"**Son of a human**,
do you see what they are doing?
The **great abominations** that **the house of Israel** are doing here,

so that they become far away from my sanctuary?

And you will see still greater abominations. "

7 **And he brought me to** the entrance of the court
and I saw and look: a hole in the wall.

8 And he said to me,
"Son of a human, dig now in the wall."
And I dug in the wall and look: a hole.

9 And he said to me,
"Go, and see the terrible abominations which they are doing there.

10 And I went and I saw, and look:
every form of creeping animal and beast, a detestable thing,
and all the dung-balls of the house of Israel were inscribed upon the wall all around.

11 And seventy men of the elders of the house of Israel,
and Ya'azanyahu son of Shaphan was standing in their midst,
they were standing before them
and each had a censor in his hand,
and the fragrance of the cloud of the incense was rising.

12 And he said to me,
"**Do you see, Son of a human,**
what the elders of the house of Israel are doing in the dark,
each in the chambers of his image?
For they are saying,
'Yahweh isn't watching us.
Yahweh has abandoned the land.'

13 And he said to me,
"**You will see still greater abominations that they are doing. "**

14 **And he brought me to** the entrance of the gate of the house of Yahweh which faces North,
and look: there were the women sitting and weeping for Tammuz.

15 And he said to me,
"**Do you see, Son of a human?**
You will see still greater abominations than these. "

16 **And he brought me to** the inner court of the house of Yahweh,
and look: at the entrance of the temple of Yahweh,
between the outer entry porch and between the altar
were about twenty-five men;
their backs were to the temple of Yahweh,

and their faces were to the East,
and they were bowing down to the East, toward the sun.

¹⁷ And he said to me,

“**Do you see, Son of a human,**

is it too small a thing for the house of Judah to do the abominations which they have done here?
for they have filled the land with violence,
and then they turned to provoke me?
And look, they are shoving the branch into their nose!”

¹⁸ And I too, I will act in hot-anger;

my eye will not show pity
and I will not show compassion
and they will call out in my hearing with a great voice,
but I will not hear them.”

Ezekiel 8:1-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Vision of the Abominations in the Temple

In Ezekiel 8:1-2, elders seek Ezekiel and he has a vision of the glory of Yahweh.

- The second date in the book is 592 B.C.E., 14 months after his first vision. This will validate his prophecies of Jerusalem’s destruction.
- The "elders" sit before Ezekiel on numerous occasions (8:1, 14:1-3, 20:1-3, 33:30-32), showing a combination of rejection and respect.
- The irony: The glory of Yahweh appears to Ezekiel in Babylon (where it “shouldn’t” be) and takes him on a tour of the temple (where it “should” be).

In Ezekiel 8:3-18, he has a vision of abominations in Jerusalem's temple.

- Ezekiel’s knowledge of the temple is demonstrated here due to his training, and his outraged vocabulary is explained here as well. He sees the tragedy and atrocity of Israel’s apostasy: “have you seen? ... you will see more” (Ezek. 8:6, 9, 13, 15, 17).
- Ezekiel is taken through four areas of the temple (getting closer to the holy of holies each time) to see the reality.

The Idol of Jealousy in the Outer Court (Ezek. 8:3-6)

This is likely a reference to the statue of Asherah erected by King Manasseh in the temple courts (see [2 Kgs. 21:3-7](#)). It was torn down by Josiah ([2 Kgs. 23:6](#)), but then restored afterwards (this is the worship of the “queen of heaven” mentioned in [Jer. 44:17-19](#)).

The chronicler’s account of Manasseh’s building of the statue incorporates Ezekiel’s description into the narration itself. The unique word “image” (סמל) is used only in these passages and in Deuteronomy 4:16, to which both Ezekiel 8 and 2 Chronicles 33 are hyperlinked.

2 Kings 21:7 NASB*

Then he set the **carved image (פסל)** of Asherah that he had made, in the house of Yahweh ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 8:5 NASB*

So I raised my eyes toward the north, and behold, to the north of the altar gate was this **idol (סמל)** of jealousy (קנאה) at the entrance.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Chronicles 33:7 NASB*

Then he put the **carved image (פסל)** of **the idol (הסמל)** which he had made in the house of *Elohim* ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The phrase “idol that causes jealousy” is a creative adaptation from the description of idols in Deuteronomy 4:16-18.

Deuteronomy 4:23-24 NASB*

²³ “So watch yourselves, that you do not forget the covenant of Yahweh your Elohim which he made with you, and make for yourselves an **image (פסל)** in the form of anything against which the Yahweh your Elohim has commanded you. ²⁴ “For the Yahweh your Elohim is a consuming fire, a **jealous (קנא) Elohim**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Animal Carvings (Ezek. 8:10)

Idolatrous images are carved into the wall of an unspecified temple chamber (converted storage room? See 1 Kgs. 6:5). The description of the creatures is lifted right out of Deuteronomy 4:17-18 and seasoned with the vocabulary of the animal list from day five of Genesis 1.

Deuteronomy 4:16-18 NASB*

¹⁶ so that you do not act corruptly and make a graven image for yourselves in the form of any figure, **the likeness (תבנית)** of male or female, ¹⁷ the likeness (תבנית) of any animal that is on the earth, the likeness (תבנית) of any winged bird that flies in the sky, ¹⁸ **the likeness (תבנית)** of anything **that creeps (רמש)** on the ground, the likeness (תבנית) of any fish that is in the water below the earth.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 1:24 NASB*

Then God said, “Let the earth bring forth living creatures after their kind: **cattle (בהמה)** and **creeping things (רמש)** and beasts of the earth after their kind”; and it was so.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

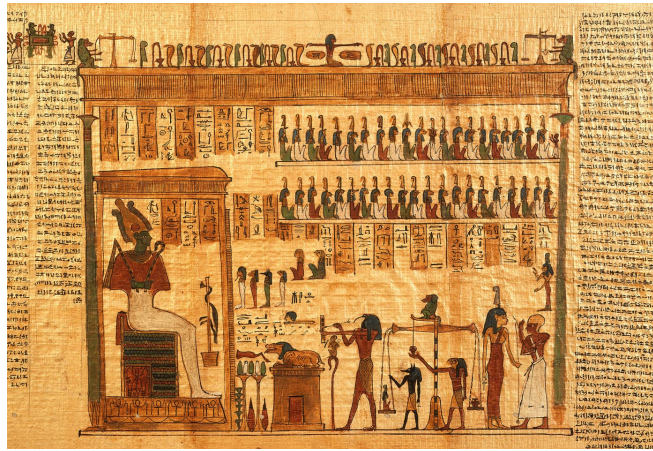
Ezekiel 8:10 NASB*

So I entered and looked, and behold, every **likeness** (תבנית) of **creeping things** (רמש) and **beasts** (בהמה) and detestable things, with all the idols of the house of Israel, were carved on the wall all around.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

There are 70 elders worshipping the animal carvings. The elders believe Yahweh has abandoned his people and so pray to other deities.

Walther Zimmerli has argued that these animal images have an Egyptian influence, which often depicted deities as snakes and beetles and reptiles ([Ezekiel 1: A Commentary on the Book of the Prophet Ezekiel, Chapters 1-24](#). Fortress Press. 240-241). For reference, see the image from the Egyptian Book of the Dead below.



Papyrus of Hunefer (1275 B.C.E.). [Wikimedia](#).

John Walton has also appealed to Babylonian influence, as their cosmic deities were often depicted as creatures. On this Babylonian stele, note the underworld creatures at the bottom (see Walton, [Zondervan Illustrated Bible Backgrounds Commentary, vol. 4](#). 422).



Kudurru (1100s B.C.E.). Louvre Museum, CCO, via [Wikimedia](#).

Women in Ritual Mourning for Tammuz (Ezek. 8:14)

Tammuz (תַּמְזוּז) is a Babylonian fertility deity (*dum-uzi* in Sumerian), whose annual death in the autumn is connected with the dying of all the crops. The ritual mourning for Tammuz in the fall (note the sixth month in [Ezek. 8:1](#) = July/August) summons him back to life in the spring.

Tammuz is an archetypal deity that merges with similar annual fertility deities in the ancient Near East. Osiris plays a similar role in Egyptian religion, Eshmun in Canaanite culture, and Adonis in Greek culture. The other main rituals connected to *dum-uzi* involves ritual sex between priestly leaders (be careful if you Google *dumuzi!*).

“In Sumerian times a complex mythology developed around this god. The literature is preoccupied especially with the death of Tammuz and his departure to the netherworld. As a result he loses his earthly kingship, his role as shepherd, and his virility. Whether an annual cycle commemorating the death and resurrection of this god, corresponding to the agricultural cycles, was celebrated in the ritual is debated. Western counterparts to Tammuz are often recognized in the Canaanite storm god Baal-Hadad and the Greek Adonis. Since this scene follows immediately after the elders’ assertion that Yahweh had abandoned the land, it appears that these women either have equated Yahweh with Tammuz as well, or they are expressing their grief at their own deity’s departure by adapting a Tammuz ritual (hence ‘the Tammuz’).”

Block, Daniel (1997). [The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 1–24 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)](#). Eerdmans. 295.

Worship of the Sun (Ezek. 8:16)

The worship of heavenly bodies by Israelites isn’t mentioned frequently in the Hebrew Bible, but the small of handful of texts make it clear what Ezekiel is referring to. The Judahite king Manasseh is said to have introduced an astral cult into the Jerusalem temple (see [2 Kgs. 21:5](#)), and it is prohibited again in [Deuteronomy 4](#).

2 Kings 21:5 NASB

For [Manasseh] built altars for all **the host of heaven** in the two courts of the house of the LORD.

2 Kings 23:11 NASB

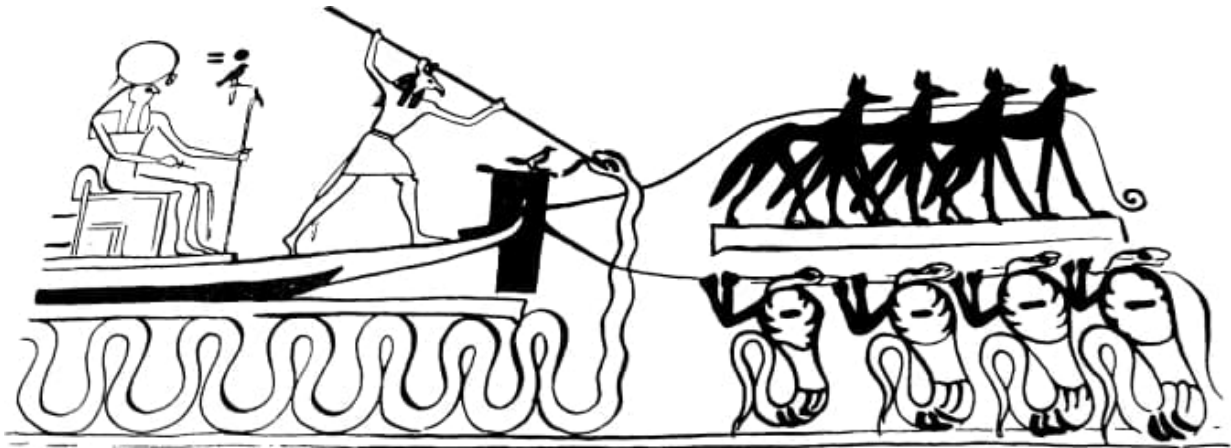
[Josiah] did away with the horses which the kings of Judah had given **to the sun**, at the entrance of the house of the LORD, by the chamber of Nathan-melech the official, which was in the precincts; and he burned **the chariots of the sun** with fire.

Deuteronomy 4:19 NASB

And beware not to lift up your eyes to heaven and see **the sun and the moon and the stars, all the host of heaven**, and be drawn away and worship them and serve them, those which the LORD your God has allotted to all the peoples under the whole heaven.

The Hebrew word for “sun” is *shemesh* (שֶׁמֶשׁ), and in both Akkadian and Ugaritic this is the proper name of the sun deity. In Egyptian culture, the sun deity was named Re, and he is often depicted as a celestial chariot rider who vanquishes the powers of darkness every morning when he rises.

The sun god Re is pulled through the underworld sea at night. The god Seth spears and defeats the death god Apophis (a snake), while the boat is pulled by subjugated night demons (jackals and snakes).



Keel, Othmar (1997). "Figure 55" (p. 55). *Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns.

Misplaced Allegiance and Idolatry Results in Violence (Ezek. 8:17)

This passage, along with the following scene in chapter 9, is riddled with language and allusions to the flood narrative in Genesis 6, and this final passage is the first clear echo.

Genesis 6:11 NASB*

Now the land became ruined in the eyes of *Elohim*, and **the land was filled with violent crime** (תמלא הארץ חמס).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 8:17 NASB*

Is it too small a thing for the house of Judah to do these abominations, that **they also fill the land with violent crime** (מלאו את הארץ חמס)

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

It is crucially important to see the link between worship, allegiance to a divine patron, and social ethics in the Hebrew Bible. In Israel's polytheistic environment, there was no assumed connection between "religion and ethics" (to use our modern categories). The gods demanded worship and certain levels of allegiance, but Yahweh was unique in that he demanded generosity and justice for the lower class as an expression of allegiance to him.

Worship was tethered to justice in a fundamental way, to a degree that was unequaled in the ancient Near East.

Ancient deities were embodiments of social institutions and natural forces, many of whom were cruel or at least uncaring for the well-being of the poor. Worship of these gods did not involve the formation of a moral

sensibility. But Yahweh worship, rooted in a conviction that every human is an image of *Elohim*, was joined with ethics.

[Ezekiel 8:1-17](#) is a classic expression of this worldview. When people give their allegiance to deities and forces other than Yahweh, it's not long before the poor suffer. See [Amos 5:21-24](#) for a classic expression of this.

Vision of Jerusalem's Destruction by "The Destroyers"

Ezekiel's vision in [chapter 9](#) is the first occurrence in the Hebrew Bible of the motif of a visionary tour guided by a divine or angelic being. Later appearances of this motif are in Zechariah 1-6, Daniel 7-12, and, in the New Testament, the Revelation. [Ezekiel 9](#) depicts the coming Babylonian siege and destruction of Jerusalem as a divinely appointed event, with Babylon as the agent of Yahweh.

Seven angelic destroyers visit Yahweh's justice on Jerusalem. The faithful remnant is "marked" and spared judgment ([9:4](#)), while the idolaters are eliminated.

The language of "do not spare and show no pity" ([Ezek. 9:5](#)) recalls the same phrase from Yahweh's orders to destroy the Canaanites ([Deut. 7:16](#); [Josh. 11:20](#); [1 Sam. 15:3, 9, 15](#)). The tragic irony is that Israel has become thoroughly Canaanized, has defiled land and temple, and so suffers the same fate (see [Lev. 18:24-28](#)).

Yahweh's glory begins to shift position away from the holy of holies ([Ezek. 9:3](#), see [Ezek. 11:22-23](#)). Ezekiel intercedes on behalf of the remnant ([Ezek. 9:8](#)), but his answer doesn't come until [Ezekiel 11:14-21](#).

Vision of the Glory of Yahweh

In [chapter 10](#), the "fire" at the center of the chariot provides for the final burning of Jerusalem ([Ezek. 9:1-7](#)). Ezekiel realizes that the "living creatures" and "wheels" of his birthday vision are in fact "cherubim" who guard and transport the divine presence ([Ezek. 10:20](#) and [verses 9-15](#)).

Yahweh's presence moves to the entrance of the temple ([Ezek. 10:18-19](#)) and prepares for takeoff.

Accusation Against the Inhabitants Left in Jerusalem

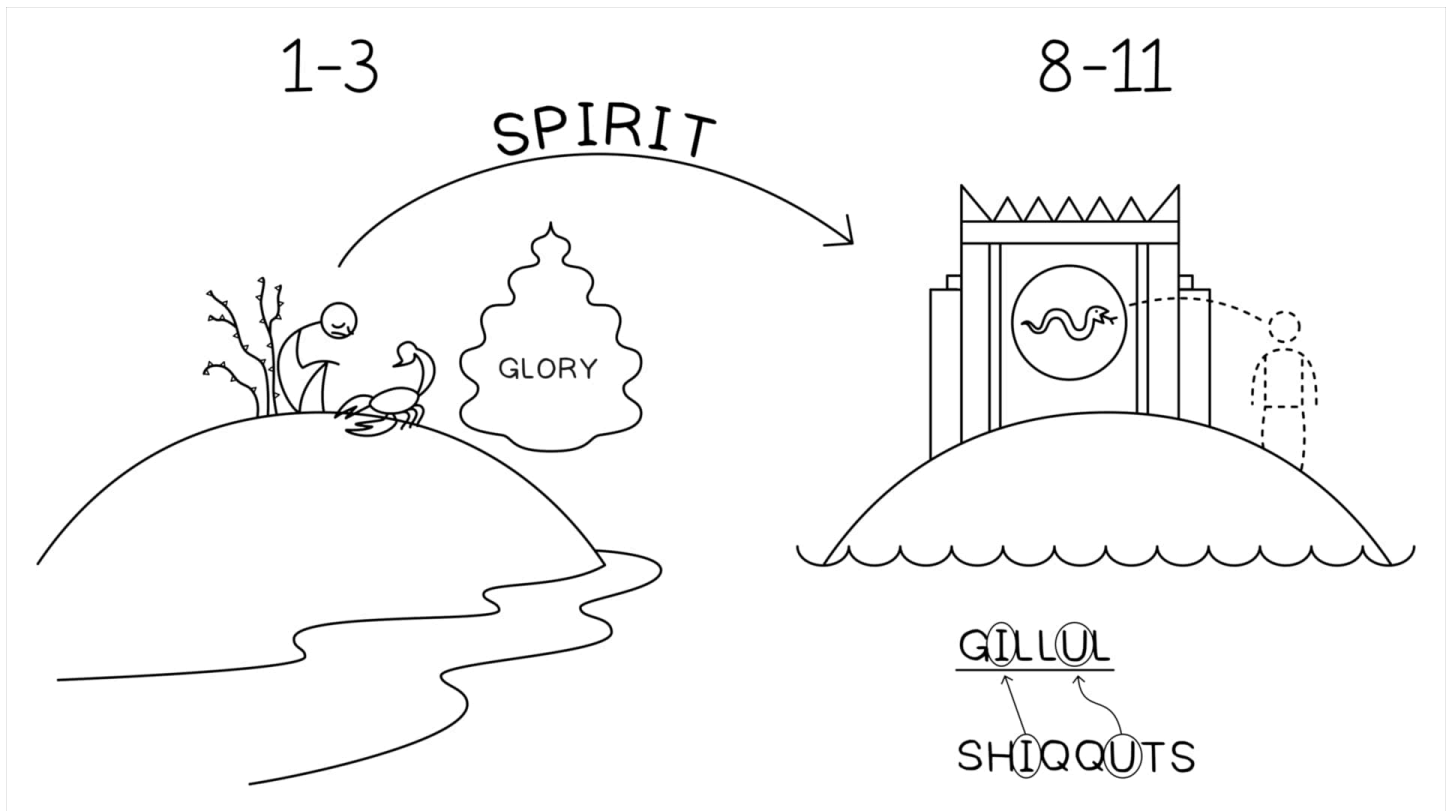
[Ezekiel 11:3](#) is unclear for several reasons.

The first part literally reads, "not in nearness is the building of houses." Possible interpretations include:

- A statement: The leaders think that there is no need to rebuild the city after the first Babylonian attack (likely because of arrogant complacency assuming the city's divine protection, as in [Jer. 14:13](#)).
- A question: "Isn't it near time to rebuild houses?" (i.e., there's nothing more to fear, the Babylonian threat is over, the ruling elite are all in exile and we can take all their leftover stuff!)

In the second half of the verse, "it is the pot" (i.e., Jerusalem is the pot) is an image of protection behind the iron walls. The line, "we are the meat" (i.e., Jerusalem's current inhabitants are choice meat) is about the status of the inhabitants of Jerusalem. Choice meat was cooked in pots; lesser cuts were cooked on open coals. The implication is that the bad cuts have been removed from the pot (i.e., the exiled leaders).

Vision of Corrupt Temple



Vision of Corrupt Temple. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

Why is idolatry such a serious issue to God?